Top Floor

By David Epstein

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *It's every parent's worst nightmare: after months of waiting, the excitement of decorating the nursery, the hopes and the dreams you held for the new addition to your family ever since the very first positive pregnancy test now you're going home empty handed.*

ACTOR: *The death of a baby is one of the most devastating experiences that anyone can go through.*

ACTRESS: *At first, it may seem almost unreal to the mother and father and they may have difficulty accepting the stillbirth. As it sinks in though, they will go through an emotional journey that will affect every aspect of their lives.*

ACTOR: *In Top Floor by David Epstein Gary and Susan are six months into this emotional journey. The question is whether they will continue to travel together.*

TOGETHER: *Top Floor by David Epstein*

Gary Lane comes through the front door with his wife, Susan. In their late thirties, they are a tall, sophisticated couple with smart clothes and tired faces. Susan shakes out a wet umbrella, takes off her coat, and examines the space. Gary sets down his wife's luggage and watches her saunter. It is raining.

GARY: Do you like it?

SUSAN: What have you done?

GARY: You don't like it.

SUSAN: I didn't say that.

GARY: Then what did you say?

SUSAN: Why didn't you tell me?

GARY: I told you.

SUSAN: But you didn't *tell me* tell me. We have an upstairs now?

GARY: Your idea.

SUSAN: Mine? *(He takes the umbrella and puts it away.)*

GARY: "We live on the top floor" is what you always used to say. "If we ever make enough

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

we should buy the roof and make this our penthouse suite." Remember?

SUSAN: That was five years ago, Gary.

GARY: *(He nods.)* Uh, huh.

SUSAN: So on a whim you decided to add a floor to our apartment?

GARY: While you were with your parents I had time to think.

SUSAN: Clearly. *(He steps up behind her; perhaps runs a finger through her hair.)*

GARY: So much has happened. It was cold this winter. For both of us. Everyone expects so much.

SUSAN: Yes.

GARY: We needed a change so I went ahead and did it. *(He kisses the back of her neck. Susan tries to be attentive but is elsewhere.)* You don't like it, do you?

SUSAN: I didn't say that. I didn't say anything.

GARY: I *know.*

SUSAN: I like it, Gary. I just walked in. I'm getting used to it. Of course I like it.

GARY: Are you sure?

SUSAN: Of course I'm sure.

GARY: Because you seem undecided.

SUSAN: I'm not undecided. I like it. *(He backs away and admires the room. He then looks to her.)*

GARY: *(Long pause.)* Really?

SUSAN: Gary!

GARY: I'm sorry. This is a big deal for me.

SUSAN: I see that. I can only say I like it so many times. It's bigger. Not so cramped. It really is what we always talked about.

GARY: You're not just saying that?

SUSAN: I'm not just saying it.

GARY: So I can show you around?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SUSAN: I wish you would.

GARY: You're not too tired?

SUSAN: *(Warning.) Gary.*

GARY: All right. First let me get your shoes. Don't want to mess up the new floor. Everything is a little out of place but is going to look great in time for spring. The view will blow your mind. There were complaints from the neighbors but that was expected.

SUSAN: About our view?

GARY: About sound, drilling, hammering, portable power generators, cranes in the street, workmen, permits. The place was a disaster zone. But it was worth it. Watch this. *(He pulls on the chord to the blinds. As they open, the lighting brings more color to the room. Susan covers her mouth and giggles.)*

SUSAN: You can see the whole city from here. Look at that!

GARY: This will be the living room. The TV goes here. Dining room and kitchen are taking over in the old bedroom. Everything else is on the second floor. Office, weight room, walk in closet, laundry room. The master bedroom is right on top of us. Plus two bedrooms in the back. Right now one of them is ... Oh! We also get the roof but that won't be ready until summer. There will be a deck and a grill. We can go up and look around when the rain stops. What else?

SUSAN: What about the room?

GARY: What?

SUSAN: You were about to say, "One of the rooms upstairs." What about it?

GARY: Oh. It's nothing. You hungry?

SUSAN: "Nothing"?

GARY: We can still order from Dynasty Bowl. They deliver until two.

SUSAN: I ate on the plane. You're not going to tell me?

GARY: I'm telling you it's not what you think.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SUSAN: Come on, Gary. You asked me to be excited, didn't you?

GARY: Susan -

SUSAN: And now I am excited and want to know even the most insignificant details. You went out on a limb, you made changes to our home, you –

GARY: *(Sharply.)* The bedroom still has the crib in it. There I said it. Let's get depressed now, OK? *(It is some time before he speaks.)* I've ... Had a lot of coffee. I was nervous about you seeing the place. I was nervous about seeing you. I still am. I wanted you to like it. I know we can have different tastes. I didn't do all this to try and make you forget.

SUSAN: You just wish I would.

GARY: No, no. That's not what I'm saying.

SUSAN: Then what?

GARY: Once in a while ... Does it hurt to try? *(Susan wraps herself in her arms)* Sue? *(No response)* Have you talked to the museum?

SUSAN: I go back in two weeks.

GARY: I'm sure they miss their curator.

SUSAN: They survived. I don't know if I'm ready. All this time off. You've spoiled me.

GARY: You can take more. *(She gives him a look.)* You don't have to work.

SUSAN: I have to work.

GARY: I mean in the great scheme of our personal economics, we –

SUSAN: I know what you mean. You've told me a thousand times.

GARY: All right -

SUSAN: What did you think? I'd get back in town and still be broken by this thing? Sit here all day and watch you bull and bear over the phone until the bell rings? Cook meals and do macrame?

GARY: Can you stop?

SUSAN: I love my job and I'm going back.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

GARY: I'm not arguing.

SUSAN: Things will be different.

GARY: Yes they will.

SUSAN: I'm not looking forward to the questions, that's all. "Where have you been? When can we see the bundle of joy?" Jesus. You've been through it. You know how awful it is to explain. I guess it's different for the man.

GARY: Why do you always say that?

SUSAN: What?

GARY: How do you know it's different? Maybe things are exactly the same. Maybe the idea of us being from different planets is a bunch of garbage we choose to believe in order to keep us from seeing how similar we really are.

SUSAN: That's real deep, sweetheart.

GARY: I'm serious.

SUSAN: I *know.*

GARY: What do you want from me? *(Exhausted.)* Maybe we should get back to trying to forget.

SUSAN: You're right. Let's forget. Novel idea. I think it's high time we forget everything we can as soon as possible.

GARY: I wish you wouldn't do that.

SUSAN: And I wish I could forget as much as you.

GARY: I didn't forget, Susan!

SUSAN: That's right! Because there is no forgetting is there, Gary?! So why bother asking me in the first place?! *(They are horrified with their raised voices. Neither knows what to say. Susan weeps softly.)*

SUSAN: I'm sorry. For a lot of things. I'm sorry that I'm crazy.

GARY: You're not crazy. You've been through something.

SUSAN: We're educated people. Raised well. We have friends. I just ... I can't stop

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

asking myself, you know - Why us?

GARY: T here is no "why." It just is.

SUSAN: Really?

GARY: Yeah.

SUSAN: Interesting. Because when I look back at how our romance began, you always used to say that, "Everything happens for a reason." But when our baby arrives dead to the world, it's, "There is no why"? *(Gives a narrow look.)* There are discrepancies in regard to which events in our life you deem as part of our destiny and which you do not. The way we met? Destiny. Our stillborn baby? Not so much.

GARY: I can't believe you.

SUSAN: What?

GARY: What? It's been six months. You chose to rush off to your parents for a half a year. You had all this time to sit on it. To "adjust." Wasn't that the word and the plan?

SUSAN: But?

GARY: But I don't know, Sue, you tell me. I look at you and I listen and I swear I feel like nothing has changed. I feel like you are still in the same state of shock you were the day you left the hospital. Why did you go away if it wasn't going to help? Why force us to go through this alone, if-You've been home ten minutes and you're picking fights?

SUSAN: You're the one who said there was an empty crib upstairs.

GARY: I did, but that isn't exactly how I described it, is it?

SUSAN: What difference does it make how you describe it?

GARY: It makes a big difference! I didn't want to talk about it.

SUSAN: Well, the next time you don't want to talk about something maybe you shouldn't bring it up.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

GARY: Jesus. I can't believe we're doing this.

SUSAN: Believe it.

GARY: You've barely scratched the surface of this thing, have you? *(For a moment they are looking at each other. He breaks off.)*

SUSAN: Tell me something.

GARY: What more do you want me to say? Everything gets me in trouble.

SUSAN: I, for one, am tired of hearing myself speak. Aren't you? *(Faint smile.)* Besides. You're better at the truth.

GARY: There is a ton of mail. Everyone sent letters of congratulations. *(He sets a small stack of cards on the table. He watches her sift through before revealing another stack.)* Two weeks later, most of the same people sent condolences.

SUSAN: How weird.

GARY: Twilight Zone. *(They sit quietly, staring at the two piles.)* You think we can we get through this?

SUSAN: It's not that much mail.

GARY: That's not what I mean.

SUSAN: I know.

GARY: We spent six months apart. We prepared ourselves. We talked about not arguing or blaming each other. We said we'd work together to stay happy.

SUSAN: How we doing?

GARY: I'm asking you.

SUSAN: I don't know, Gar. The idea of working to stay happy seems a bit counterproductive. We're either going to be happy or we're not.

GARY: Well? Are we?

SUSAN: I don't know. *(Silence.)*

GARY: Do you still love me? *(She does not answer. Gary nods with uncertainty then goes through the stack. Susan watches for a long beat before she starts to help.)*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: David Epstein
Book: 2006: The Best Ten-Minute Plays for Two Actors
ISBN: 978-1575255637
Publisher: Smith and Kraus
Date (Month/Year): November 2007

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY